

Conrad Gavel

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling threatened to expose a private sale you arranged outside your auction house's normal process unless you waived a substantial fee.

What you are hiding

You did route the sale through a discreet subsidiary to satisfy a client who insisted on anonymity. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Grant once handled a disputed certificate that Sterling could use against him.
- Daphne quietly sold a work she had once spoken of as a future institutional gift.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You were loudly arguing with Grant about buyer premiums during the critical minutes, witnessed by Daphne.

IF MURDERER

You entered at 6:44 with a valuation sheet, poisoned the cordial, and left the auction pencil you used to stir it.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I arranged a private sale through a discreet subsidiary because a client demanded anonymity. Sterling knew and intended to use it to erase a fee he owed me. Unsavory, perhaps. Murderous, no. Grant and Daphne can both place me in a very public argument while the poison was added.

IF MURDERER

Sterling wanted a private transaction when it benefited him and a public scandal when it benefited him more. I brought the valuation sheet, stirred poison into his cordial with my auction pencil, and left the pencil behind. I have spent forty years telling people when the bidding is over. Tonight I ended it myself.

Investigation notes
